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Lonnie Liston Smith

Keyboardist and composer Lonnie Liston Smith has made a significant contribution to the jazz canon, most notably with his group The Cosmic Echoes. His signature compositions include "Astral Traveling" and "A Garden of Peace."

Lonnie was interviewed via Zoom on January 9, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very privileged to have Lonnie Liston Smith with me today for the Fillius Jazz Archive oral history program. Thanks for joining me.

LLS: All right, okay, great.

MR: You look well, am I correct that you just celebrated your 80th birthday not long ago?

LLS: Oh yeah, yeah, the 28th of December.

MR: So you're in your home, you're sitting in front of your piano. When you go to your instrument these days just to play, do you have any kind of routine that you go to get something started?

LLS: No. Well sometimes you might just, you just, because we haven't performed in a long time. So you know you might just do some exercises, stuff like that. You know. [plays]. Keep your fingers loose, and you know so you do things like that. And sometimes you might be just playing at the piano or something, you know, you get a creative spark and that leads to something else.

MR: Yes, isn't that interesting how if you could cause a creative spark to happen on purpose we would like do it all the time.

LLS: Oh see that's the thing about creativity. Yeah, I mean real creativity. You know you never know when it's going to come, where. Because I used to live in New York and I used to go to Manny's, because that was back in the day that was on 48th Street where all the music stores were. And then you'd go in the store Manny's and you'd check out the new keyboards and you'd be checking out keyboards and all of a sudden you'd check out a keyboard and you'd do something and man there comes the sound.

MR: Yeah there's a famous story about that with you. We'll get that later, all right? When we talk about Pharoah.

LLS: Oh yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: Yeah.

LLS: I'm seeing a thing in front of me. This meeting is being recorded?

MR: Yes.

MR: Yes.

LLS: Oh perfect okay. I thought I did something wrong. Perfect.

MR: No, I think you're good. You and I are like, I'm not sure how technical you are but I am not that great at it so this is —

LLS: Oh no, I'm the same way.

MR: It's a bit of a miracle I guess. You attended music college. I wonder if you had intentions to be a music teacher?

LLS: No, but I'm glad — I went to, when I finished high school, Armstrong High School in Richmond, Virginia, because my whole family was always music. And my father was in a harmonizing Gospel group, the Harmonizing Four Gospel group. And so I was just surrounded by music from day one and then actually you said earlier, you've got that poster by you of Charlie Parker. I was in high school when I heard Charlie Parker play "Just Friends" with strings over at someone's house. That's when I said well what is he doing? They say — because it was so beautiful. They say he's playing jazz and doing improvisation. I said oh man, that's what I want to do. So when I left Richmond I thought I was going to New York but, I'm glad I did go to Morgan State University which was in Baltimore.

MR: Did they have any programs at that time that were — addressed jazz? Or were you more learning the classical theory and so forth?

LLS: Just basic classical theory. Because back then, when I was back there they hadn't even started these jazz colleges and universities yet. But at that time in Baltimore, Maryland it was very, very musical. And all the jazz groups used to come down and play on Pennsylvania Avenue and so Baltimore was kind of like New York because you had the — New York had the Apollo Theater. And Baltimore, the same groups would come and do the Royal Theater in Baltimore, then they would go to Washington, DC and do the Howard Theater. And so music was everywhere between Washington and Baltimore, which is right together. And then actually Gary Bartz I had met, Gary Bartz is from Baltimore, so we both were what, 18, 19, 20? We used to hang out. And we ended up playing together in his father's club called the North End Lounge, and so Baltimore was very musical back then.

MR: What would your set list have been like, playing with Gary Bartz at that time?

LLS: Oh we were just doing standards you know. Just basic standards and what was it, what did I do, oh shoot, what did we do?

[plays]

MR: Oh yeah, Randy Weston. "High Fly"?

LLS: I forgot it. Then you know we'd do something like that

So it's just basic standards. I wasn't writing back then. So but the North End Lounge, all the jazz groups when they came in town they would come by and do jam sessions. So like you know, so I was really in school in another way, both schools at the same time.

MR: Yes. This time was formative for you as a bunch of years before the real books came on the scene.

LLS: Right.

MR: So if you had to learn a tune, how did you go about doing that?

LLS: Well we used to listen to the records or some of the older guys would know the changes, the chord changes. Because it was funny, you know we used to go sit in with the older guys and sometimes you know the bass player would have to be telling you the chord changes while you're playing. That was interesting, because I remember when you're in school they would say okay C minor with a diminished fifth. Or C minor with a augmented fifth. But see when you're on the bandstand you have a tempo. So they say C minor flat five. Or F7 plus — so it was good. And like I say it was two different schools at the same time.

MR: Yeah, trial by fire.

LLS: Right, that's it, okay.

MR: I want to go back a little bit. Let's say you were 13 or so, 1953, and your family was very into Gospel music. If you had brought home a record by Louis Jordan or some of the, you know the blues guys, would that have been accepted in your household?

LLS: Oh that's why I was really blessed man, actually I've got two younger brothers who were very challenging. And my father played the four string guitar and he had a beautiful tenor voice. My two younger brothers got that tenor voice. But he loved music. He told me they would perform at the Apollo Theater and he would go, after that he would go listen to all the jazz groups, and he'd come back home and tell me about them and we'd go down in the basement and we'd listen to records, or back then you know the radio was the main thing. And so it was interesting you know because I loved Duke Ellington and Count Basie, but he knew all about Fletcher Henderson. I didn't know anything about Fletcher Henderson. And he would tell me, say yeah, you've got to listen to him because you know people overlooked him. And so I was really blessed. My father, he just loved all music.

MR: Can you recall the first gig you ever played where you made some money?

LLS: Yeah, I guess. We were just doing regular things, you know, what was that, just regular rhythm & blues

[plays].

You know we was doing all that kind of stuff. So you know we had a group, I guess it

MR: It's funny you mention that, that's the picture of Charlie Parker over my shoulder, the Metronome All-Stars.

LLS: Well I'll be darned. Okay.

MR: The spirits are with us. Well most of your generation seems like New York beckoned. Did you feel prepared when you went there in 1963 or did you just have faith?

LLS: Oh, that's it. In my case I definitely had faith. Because I didn't know anything about New York City and so it was just faith. I didn't know anyone and so you just start going around to jam sessions. I remember I caught the tail end of Birdland, you know, the real Birdland I guess, right here on Broad Street. Broadway — I'm thinking of Richmond — Broadway, and you'd go down in the basement and so you know you'd listen and I think one night I tried to sit in but I didn't know, I just climbed on stage and so but that's a good way of putting it. In my case it was just pure faith.

MR: Did you have to work a day job, like to get by?

LLS: No because you do a lot of jobs as sideman and then what happens certain people hear you and start spreading your name around. And they said, "Oh man, we've got this new kid in town, plays piano, he sounds pretty good." Then you start getting calls. I think — oh in the beginning I went on the road with a lot of singers, you know, Betty Carter — for some reason Betty Carter always knew the new pianists when they came in town, and there was the Dakota Staton, Al Hibbler, Joe Williams, and then, you know I got a call from Rahsaan Roland Kirk and was there for a while. And then the next thing I think was Max Roach. I was with Art Blakey and the Jazz Messengers for a while, and Chuck Mangione was playing trumpet in the group. So you just keep building like that then eventually you get a call from Miles.

MR: You know I saw Rahsaan in probably 1968 or 9, and what a force of nature he was.

LLS: That's a good way of putting it. Because Rahsaan, he had the nose flute, then he played the three horns, and you know it made sense because he'd make the harmony and everything. And oh I know one time we was on the road and he went to New Orleans, you know, like on vacation, him and his wife. And man when he came back, for a whole week all he wanted to do was play the clarinet. Because you know that's the big thing in New Orleans. So you know that was interesting. So we used to say uh oh — for a whole week he played the clarinet. But you know Rahsaan, I think he was the first to play the three horns.

MR: I believe you're right. You know some fellas have done two but, yeah I kept thinking how the heck does he do that. And then I got to see him and I still didn't believe it.

LLS: Oh yeah, I know. The way he hooked them up, then he had that nose flute. That was something. But it — because actually my first recordings we did "Here Comes the

in VanGelder's studio, which is fantastic. So those were my first two recordings with Rahsaan.

MR: Working with singers, you're going to go from you may be playing the same tune with two different singers but one's a man and one's a woman, and you've got to know — you've got to be flexible, right? You've got to play it in A flat instead of E flat?

LLS: Right. Oh yeah. Oh that's it. You've definitely got to be flexible. And then you know, but working with singers, it's a good experience for keyboard players. Because when you're playing with a band you could be more forceful. But for high singers you've got to be sensitive and you've really got to listen. So that's a good experience for you. But I'll tell you one thing, man, working with Betty Carter, Monk, that was interesting. Because Betty Carter was like a horn player. Because you know she based her singing on horn players and then so with Betty you could just play. So you know Betty Carter, that's really a great opportunity.

MR: Well actually you mentioned Joe Williams and he helped us get this project started that we're doing.

LLS: Okay. Oh yeah Joe was something because he's the champion of Count Basie and all the experiences. And then you know Joe Williams, he worked what I'd say more high class venues and rooms. So it was great. Because like you say he was with Count Basie and Vegas, he's been everywhere.

MR: Did you have any issues traveling with bands in — we're talking let's say the early 60s now, traveling around the country? What was that like?

LLS: It didn't bother me because being born and raised in the south, in Richmond, Virginia, so you know you just get used to — you just let things go in one ear and right out the other. But I noticed back then though a lot of times you had to travel by car, that's what my father and them did in the Harmonizing Four. And I think I messed up because when I was with Art Blakey and the Jazz Messengers, I was supposed to — he was going to California and he did a — was going to do a recording, I think at Shelly Manne's Hole or something. And the record was out and Chuck was one, but we all had to get in our car, it was six of us, and put the things on top. And I said I'm not going to California like that. But I shoulda went because they did a recording. But that's the way it goes.

MR: You know I had written a question down for later but I'll ask it now because you said, "I'm not going to California like that." And I wondered if over your career you have ever turned down a recording or a chance to play with some band for some personal reasons?

LLS: No. It was — everything, because you know each was a different experience. Okay now when I was with Max Roach, you know we performed and Max loved to do all these different times. So I understood 5/4 but 7/4 and 13 and all that, that's a little bit difficult.

the road to be Abbey Lincoln's musical director, and that was another good experience. But one night we was in New York and he called me and said, "You know Papa Jo Jones had had an engagement at the Village Gate" and he needed a keyboard player, or a pianist. And Max said, "Would you go to that," because you know him and Papa Jo were really tight. He said, "I want you to go down there and work with Papa Jo. So you know I'm young, I'm thinking oh shoot, you know, Papa Jones. But actually that was one of the best experiences I had. Papa Jo taught me so much about history, you know, because he went back further than Max. And then he used to tell me about how the drummers and the tap dancers, they considered the tap dancers drummers but they were doing it with their feet. And they would exchange fours and eights. So that was, so you never know how you're going to learn things.

MR: Yeah. Have you ever been in a rhythm section where the bass player and the drummer didn't seem to be on the same page?

LLS: Oh yeah well that happened a lot. You know so then you've really got to be flexible. You know you've got to listen to both and you might have to just get in the middle. Because I remember, what's the guy's name who was working with Miles, the bass player. Not Ron Carter, before Ron, oh he's really an excellent bass player.

MR: Paul Chambers?

LLS: No not Paul, it was after Paul, and I guess it will come back to me. But he's really great. So he was in the group and I think Herbie was doing one thing and I think Tony Williams was playing it — you know Tony what is 18, 19, 20? He's doing something else. So he asked Miles, "What am I supposed to do?" Miles said, "You just, you have to be, if they play fast you play slow." I mean you have to really adjust.

MR: I was thinking the other day about in the 80s they had this term in jazz, the "young lions." We had a lot of young guys coming up, and they were making albums as leaders when they were in their early 20s. You were like 33 I think when you became a leader.

LLS: Right.

MR: Okay. Did you, how should I say this, did you wait on purpose or were you just waiting for the opportunity?

LLS: I guess waiting for opportunity because I was — I mean I just loved music. So I was playing, — when I left home I said I want to work with all the masters. And so I worked with Max, I worked with Art Blakey, and I think he did something with Mingus. So I met all of them, so when I was with Art Blakey I had a chance to hang out with Monk one night. Monk came down to hang out with Art, so I hung out with Monk and that was a pleasant surprise because you know everyone was saying Monk is so eccentric, but man, shoot, Monk talked for about 24 hours. I said wow. And Bird was there. So I was just

Miles I said oh boy, now I have arrived you know. Because Miles was the icing on the cake. But all before that Bob Thiele had Flying Dutchman Records. So I had recorded, you know, all the things with Pharoah Sanders, I recorded with Gato Barbieri, I was doing most all the Flying Dutchman records. So when I was with Miles Bob Thiele called me and said, "Lonnie, people are talking about you all over the world, so it's time for you to do your own record." I said okay, I'll do my own record. So we did the record and I called it "Astral Traveling" and I was still with Miles. So I went back and I used Mtume, he was on "Astral Traveling." He was in Miles' group at the time. I used a tabla player from India, Badal Roy, and so after I did the record I was going back to working with Miles. I was happy. So then months later I get a call from Bob Thiele and he said, "Lonnie, you've got to put a band together." I said, "Why? I'm with Miles. I'm happy." He said, "You've got to support this record." And so I told Miles, I said, "Miles I've got to "— I had to leave the band because I've got to support the record. I don't want — so Miles just looked at me and said, "Why'd you do the record?" Because I didn't know the whole procedure. And so that's what happened. And then I did the two records. And then when I did "Expansions" oh man it just took off.

MR: When you did which record?

LLS: "Expansions" that was the third record.

MR: Yeah. I was reading about your time with Miles and I wondered if when those records came out that you played on if you were anxious to see if they credited you, because there was an awful lot of people involved in those things I think.

LLS: Yeah. They finally gave me credit for — I think — because they sent me, years later, "On the Corner" they gave me credit for "Ife" I think. But it was, like you say, shoot, when I first got the call to do a Miles I think they was working on something and I walked into the studio and there's three keyboards. So I assumed that I was supposed to wait my turn. I didn't know — because back then Miles was really experimenting. And so I was standing up against the wall and Miles walked over and said what the bleep you waiting for? And there's Herbie on one keyboard and another pianist. And I'm saying, oh man, I never even played with another keyboard player, now there's three of us. So I mean, Monk, I had to really listen, because you know we can't all play the same thing, we can't get in each other's way. And so, and then I just learned about the Fender Rhodes when I was doing "Thembi" with Pharoah. So when I got with Miles I said oh man I'm going to really get into the Fender Rhodes. So I go to Miles' house one day and I said, "Well Miles, where's the Fender Rhodes?" He said, "Oh no, I'm tired of that." Because you know he had Herbie Hancock play the Fender Rhodes, Chick Corea, Joe Zawinul. He said, "I want another sound." And I said, "Well what am I supposed to play?" So the

Jimmy Smith, it was like a regular keyboard, electric keyboard. So he said, "I want you to play that." So I said, "Well Miles, I never played it." He said, "Oh that's fantastic." I said, "Well Miles, can I take it home and practice?" "Oh no, no, no." So Monk, I had to learn the keyboard and play, and create on stage. But that's what Miles wanted. He'd get mad if you didn't come up with anything creative each night. And you know that's hard for somebody that wants you to really create and be yourself.

MR: That's a great story. So this morning I was doing a little ear training.

LLS: Okay.

MR: I put on "Astral Traveling" and so you're going to tell me if I got anything close here. I've got a little keyboard here.

LLS: Uh oh. All right.

[audio interlude]

MR: So is that anything like the chord you played?

LLS: Right. You're playing an F with an F sus we call it.

MR: That's right. That's right. Now I was hoping to get the next chord. Is it [strikes chord]

LLS: F minor.

MR: F minor?

LLS: Right.

MR: Okay.

LLS: And then — the first is F sus then the second one is F minor, and back to the F sus, then a D flat major 7.

MR: Oh yeah.

LLS: C 7, back to the F sus. And do you know, I call it, it's a twelve bar, I call it the twelve bar cosmic blues. Oh man, it just came. We were in the studio out there and I had never seen a Fender Rhodes. So I asked the engineer — before that I played all the grand pianos. So you know the grand piano you don't have to do anything. So I said, "Well what is that?" So the engineer said, "That's a Fender Rhodes." I said, "Wow, I never played it." So everybody else are unpacking instruments, setting up drums. So I walked over and started messing with the knobs and Monk, it just came and it turned out to be, you know a twelve bar blues but the different voicing. Because you know regular blues is nothing but a 1-4-5 [plays].

Then it's C. But this one, you know

[plays]

So that was, and man they ran over and said, "Man what was that?" I said, "I'm writing this song." "Oh we've got to record that right now, and so what are you going to call it?" And I was studying at that time, astral projection you know, how if you eat right and

we're traveling all over the world, let's call it "Astral Traveling." And that's what happened.

MR: That's great. What a story. And did Pharoah sort of improvise the melody?

LLS: In a way, yeah. Right, right. Because I put a melody to it and copyrighted it, but what happened was, and then someone bought — I was telling the rest of the story and they said, I think that was the first time Pharoah played soprano.

MR: And you did your own version of it on your —

LLS: First album.

MR: Yeah. And I'm assuming that you sort of wrote out the melody with a little more precision?

LLS: Right. And so you know that was it. And we did it. But back then, you know, everything was just more creative. Because we did that whole record in one night and I mean we was just very creative, every time Pharoah and Leon. Leon Thomas always got together. You could start with something and then you just keep exploring and just keep going.

MR: You know it takes an open-minded producer I think to just, or at least someone who just stays out of the way.

LLS: Monk that's the whole key. 'Cause Bob Thiele never got in the way but I guess you know he — Bob Thiele produced all those records by John Coltrane. And then he told me a story about the record he produced with John Coltrane and Duke Ellington. And Bob Thiele, you know, if you let him he'd have you doing two and three takes. So Duke Ellington and Trane, they performed the song so Bob came out and said, "Okay let's do another take." Duke Ellington told him, said, "No, it's going to be different anyway."

MR: The sound that you got on the Rhodes and carried you through different recordings, were you hearing that, I mean there was a lot of tremolo, some reverb, some effects. I'm trying to think how to ask this question. When you were recording were you hearing those effects or were they added later?

LLS: Oh no. Oh it was right there. What happened was you know that's why I got kind of upset because I think the Fender Rhodes did a documentary on the Fender Rhodes and I don't know why they didn't call. Because Chick and everyone else, and Herbie, they approached the Fender Rhodes the same way you approach the grand piano but you can't do that. Because the Fender Rhodes is a different color and different sounds. So I was approaching the Fender Rhodes from the sound and the colors that were coming out of the Fender Rhodes. So you can't play it like — you're not playing a grand piano. So, and then when I was with Miles, Miles had all these pedals hooked up to his trumpet. So when I got to the Fender Rhodes I said well let me do the same thing Miles did, but I'm going to hook the pedals up to the Fender Rhodes. And Monk, it worked. I came up with,

MR: That's terrific. Your family I guess was, is it fair to say your family was religious?

LLS: Oh yeah.

MR: So was there a spiritual thread throughout your life that stayed with you and when you became a leader what role did it play in the music you created?

LLS: That was it. Because you know people don't realize the church is very important, you know, for us I guess as black people, because even with Trane, his father and grandfather was preachers. Aretha Frank— that church, you grow up in it and the music is fantastic and so what I did was, you know, I took that spirituality and all of a sudden I became aware of Eastern philosophy and different religions and I started studying them and then you find out, well wait a minute, all religions and all philosophies are basically saying the same thing. Everybody wants peace, harmony and enlightenment. So I said well why are we doing all the wars and fighting each other. And I started writing, the first time I wrote [inaudible] was on "Expansions." And that's when I said expand your mind so we can have a vision of a new world where everyone would live in peace and harmony. You know a good example is what happened last Wednesday [January 6, 2021]. You know we were having all this craziness going on and so I just took that spirituality from that, from the Baptist church, and just kept expanding it to a whole universal consciousness.

MR: Some of the things you did with Pharoah Sanders, the music would be going along sort of peaceful, and then something would happen.

LLS: That's a good point. That was the thing I really brought to Pharoah. Because I said well you know we'd be playing and we'd just keep on exploring. And I remember I had ten fingers and I said wait a minute — and Pharoah was getting all these sounds, I said I need more sounds. So I used my fingers and then I used my elbows, you know, to get a bigger sound. And, but it was all musical, we wasn't banging or nothing, but so I told Pharoah, I said, Pharoah, we can't leave the people out there. We've got to bring them back. So we'd be playing then all of a sudden then we'd come on back to what they're used to. [plays] You know so I always told Pharoah, I said Pharoah we've got to bring them back the way we started. And it worked.

MR: It surely did.

LLS: Because you can leave them out there, like you say, it got strange.

MR: I had the pleasure of doing an interview with Cecil McBee.

LLS: Oh man, that's great.

MR: What a wonderful guy. And I tried to ask a question. It had something to do with Charlie Parker and his generation and spirituality. And I guess I was asking him if the music of those masters from the 40s and so forth was less spiritual than things he was involved in with you and Pharoah. And I'm going to read what he said and ask for your comment on

it. He said "Well if it ain't spiritual don't play it. Your spirit is what makes you play the instrument."

LLS: Oh that makes sense. Oh man, look at all those great things Duke Ellington did. And when I heard Charlie Parker playing "Just Friends" with strings I mean I couldn't believe it. You know because I'm coming from a Gospel background and I heard all this beauty, oh no, the music was and is, I mean you know real music, and real creative music and real musicians they're really playing from their inner being and their heart and their soul. I mean that's automatically spiritual. Oh man, no, no indeed, they were definitely spiritual but they might not have said anything or talked about it but the music was fantastic.

MR: Yes. Well I'm glad you said that and I think the reason one of my favorite musicians has always been Cannonball Adderley, and boy, he had some spirit.

LLS: Oh shucks, I mean Cannonball, because for a while there what was so in me, I was so busy listening to Trane I was overlooking Cannonball. Then later on I started listening to Cannonball on YouTube and everything. I said oh my goodness, I mean Cannonball was playing but I was so busy listening to Trane and oh man, shoot. Cannonball and that group he had with his brother, oh man.

MR: Have you been able to keep ownership over the years of your own music?

LLS: Yeah, yeah, Monk, like I said I was really blessed because I didn't know anything about the music industry. A good example like when I did the third album, "Expansions," and the record came out, I mean the record took off real wide. People were calling RCA and all over the world they said we need — so we had a rush back and reprint all kinds of new records and ship them out. And then they called me up and they said, "Lonnie, you've got to get a manager right away, you've got to" — they said, "you're on the charts." Monk I was so naive I asked, I said what charts? You know the Billboard charts and everything. And like you said Bob Thiele stayed out of the way. So Bob Thiele, a lot of the record companies would, you know, would take your publishing, but Bob Thiele, like you said, he stayed out of the way and I ended up with my publishing. And then later on in life I wrote a song in the studio one day, I just said, you know, I just want to play something beautiful. And I wrote a song called "A Garden of Peace" and I mean I'm talking about years later all of a sudden all the young kids all over the world, they fell in love with it. Jay-Z sampled it, Mary J. Blige sampled it, they all sampled it and sampling the song, and I didn't expect that. It blew me away 'cause it's just a beautiful song, I played the grand piano then I overdubbed the electric piano. And I mean they loved it.

MR: Can you describe how that song got started?

LLS: Well I was sitting out there and I say

But actually it's two parts to it, when you listen to the record, but they took that part of it, 'cause it's

[plays]

that's the part, I mean they love it. And so the young kids are saying, when they sample it they put a different beat to it. Each one. So they said, well why don't you put your beat to it, so I said, oh, so this happened two or three years ago so I said okay

[plays]

then the playing comes in

[plays]

So they love it.

MR: I love it too.

LLS: Okay.

MR: Well this is not a personal question but I guess I'm just curious, when you go to your mailbox everyday do you sometimes expect payments from these people or these companies that are using your music?

LLS: Oh yeah well what happens is well you know — I know you know — you have BMI and you've got ASCAP. So I'm with BMI. And so every time it's played or performed on the TV or radio, you know, it's recorded that there be, that's when you look for things. Or you have a company like Universal Music or someone to administrate things, because it's happening all over the world so you know I can't check everything all over the world.

MR: Well I'm glad it seems to be, that the protocols are in place that you're being recognized and compensated for that.

LLS: Yeah.

MR: Over the years changing musical styles, I'm wondering — I'll preface this with the fact that I've been playing gigs for about fifty years myself and —

LLS: Oh okay.

MR: And I'm always paying attention to what seems to work with different audiences. So my question I'm trying to form is have you taken into consideration the idea of trying to sell more records when you write music or create your recordings, or is that not really part of your thinking?

LLS: No. Like I said I did "Expansions" and it just took off, and then "A Garden of Peace." Because that's what happens, as you know the record companies put a lot of pressure on you, you know 'cause everybody wants a gold record or a platinum record. And so that was one reason I was in the studio that day and I wrote "A Garden of Peace" I said, oh shoot, I just want to do something beautiful and peaceful. And like years later it paid off. So but I — oh Bob Thiele used to always mess with me. He said man look why don't you

cosmic, come on now." And he'd do it on purpose, you know but like I say I was just fortunate and blessed you know that these songs just took off and stood on their own. Because Herbie Hancock, he's written some beautiful songs, and Wayne Shorter. So I don't think they was trying to write hits but they became hits.

MR: Yeah. That's the best way for it to happen I think.

LLS: Yeah.

MR: Earlier on when you were talking about astral projecting and out of body, have you ever had what you would describe as an out of body experience playing with either your own group or with Pharoah?

LLS: Well they told us something one time, oh yeah, when the music gets going I mean you just playing, so I mean there is no such thing as a body or whatever. I mean you're into the music and nothing else exists. But we used to perform at a lot of the universities and one of them was in Philadelphia, was Temple University. And we did a concert one night and the people said, "I wish I had videotaped it." They said, "We know you all were playing and you all levitated." I said okay. "I wish I had videotaped this." But I can't prove it, but I mean when the music is really going and you really get into the music it's just sound so I mean so you're not even aware of anything else. But those are the moments that you look for, that make it worthwhile.

MR: A lot of the music that you recorded over the years has been — used extended vamps.

LLS: Right.

MR: And were you ever in a position where you're saying well we've been playing this vamp for eight minutes now, and I don't know what to do with it anymore?

LLS: No. That's the whole thing is I remember you have to — the thing is if you can get so you're trying, every night, you've got to play certain songs anyway so you've got to try to approach the song, if you can, as if you're playing it for the first time. If you can do that then that's the key. You're approaching the song for the first time and so it's brand new, then you might try to find some different voicings and — but if you've got a very creative bass player and drummer and sometimes you use a guitarist, because I don't like guitars that play chords, I want them to play those single notes, I don't know what they call them, but so — and you might get a spark from the drummer or the bassist. And I've always been fortunate because my younger brother Donald, when he was singing in a group, he had perfect pitch and so we could just play. So he has perfect pitch, it doesn't matter what chord I play. I can just play like I'm playing with a horn player. And then I found another young singer I heard, the drummer with Lee Pearson, he's very talented. But his sister, Tabitha Pearson, I use her lately and she has perfect pitch. So you can be playing, what was that song, we do a song and it ends on a

You know with that flatted fifth but that won't bother her, she was just singing. So, but you can't do that with a lot of singers.

MR: Did Leon Thomas have that kind of flexibility?

LLS: Yeah, oh yeah. That was the thing about Leon, that's how we all got together. Because I said well dang, how can you play more than one note? You know with a horn player, can't play but one note at a time. But he has figured out ways to sound like he's playing more than one note. Then Leon was doing yodeling. And then I was doing a little bit different things on the keyboard so Pharoah said man, you know why don't we all just get together? And it worked. Because no one else was doing the yodeling at that time like Leon Thomas. And so that's what I'm saying, for some reason back in the 70s everybody was creative. I think everybody, the people are saying now, because I did a concert in California in February. And they're really into the 70s, I noticed the young kids are now. If you notice their dress, hairstyle, they are saying that the 70s was the most — musically and everything — was the most creative period that they can remember.

MR: I wonder if that has anything to do with technology. If we look back on the 70s we sort of smile at the level of technology was so far behind where it is now, but as you say, there was some great creativity going on at that time.

LLS: Oh yeah. Because I mean, that's a good point. Because the keyboards today they mess with me, because they're far advanced. But the Fender Rhodes we just played, it was easy. And so Miles hooked up those pedals so let me hook those same pedals up to everything. For some reason it was easier. But now, oh man you try to go inside the keyboard and try to figure out what to do, you have to get a tech.

MR: Yes, this is new and improved, Lonnie.

LLS: Right.

MR: You know I used to have the Fender Rhodes suitcase.

LLS: That's the one. That's the real one.

MR: That was the one, man. I can't say I miss moving it though.

LLS: Oh people don't know, that was a trip. But that one had the better sound.

MR: Yes. I won't forget seeing Cannonball once at some kind of museum or something they were playing in. And in they walk and Joe Zawinul and one other guy on the other end, they're moving their own Fender Rhodes, and I always remembered that.

LLS: Monk, that's deep, I know. Mm, mm, mm.

MR: Bringing us up to current times, do you have any thoughts about why not only our country but the world seems to be in such crisis?

LLS: That's the good part about — that's, because I'm getting a lot of, what is it, FaceBook and Instagram and people saying all over the world now they're revisiting a lot of those

Garden of Peace." That was the reason I wrote all those songs because back then we had the Vietnam war and all that, and a lot of other craziness. But now, and like I said, last Wednesday, I don't know what they're going to do about that, Monk, because you can't take things that far. And the whole world saw it. I mean that went over the whole world on TV and — because people don't realize now that what you call it — the cable and — when we go overseas we're watching the same shows as if we're at home. And then you can go online and it's just like you being at home. I can be in Japan or Europe and so the world is that small now. So I just hope people realize that if we don't work together, you know, we're going to destroy each other and destroy the whole world. Because I mean at one time in America, America was the greatest so far as everything was manufactured in America and things were created here. But now, I listened this morning, they were saying they made a deal, they're shipping things to other countries to be made and shipped back to America. So I think we have a lot to work on.

MR: Could you have written a song like "A Garden of Peace" if you were in turmoil? If your spirit was not at peace? If you weren't at peace yourself?

LLS: Right. I don't think so because I always took my time dealing with life. And then at one time I was with, you know I found out, I was with Sri Chinmoy because Santana and Mahavishnu, the guy who started Mahavishnu, John McLaughlin.

MR: Yes.

LLS: And they were with Sri Chinmoy. That's where Santana gets all its spirituality from. And even Narada Michael Walden, they were all in there together. And I came in right after they left and that's what I found out — you know meditation really works. And then Sri Chinmoy used to have vegetarian restaurants and health food stores. So you know I always tried to stay on top of taking care of yourself. Because you know musicians, right, if you study musicians back in the day now you say were they spiritual, they were spiritual, but man they used to stay out all night and drink and smoke cigarettes and all that stuff was tearing their bodies up and so I tried to be aware of that.

MR: Is there anything these days that makes you angry?

LLS: Well you get upset when somebody tried to take advantage of you. You get upset about that. So you just have to — but that's one thing about living in New York — that song is true, if you can make it there you can make it anywhere. So you know you get used to all the con games and all this slicksters and so, a lot of the time you can see things coming. And that was the beauty — when I worked with Miles I enjoyed just hanging out with Miles. Because I knew he was a musical genius, you didn't even have to think about that. But what impressed me with Miles was I mean he could just see things coming. I mean he would see somebody walking toward him and I know they're going to ask me to sniff

could go and hang with the guys "On the Corner" and they would be happy and then he would go hang with the guys who played classical music, they would be happy. Everywhere he went, the actresses and dancers, they all were crazy about him. So I mean that's the one thing I like about Miles, how can he just go from one — I'll say "genre" — to another or one group, and he'll still be Miles. So that's amazing.

MR: I'm about to wrap up here, but when I look at the recordings of that time, Pharoah Sanders' time and into the 70s, it doesn't look like there was a lot of white musicians, if any, that sort of participated in that style of music. In fact I think you had Joe Beck in your first group?

LLS: Oh yeah, well Bob — Bob wanted Joe in because Joe did some recordings. Because I remember the record, oh shoot, that's another story. When Gato — we were on the road one time, we had Stanley Clarke on bass and Airto was playing drums. So we were in Philadelphia and the last night of the engagement in Philadelphia Stanley and Airto told Gato, he said, "Well we'll see you — we're getting ready to go to California." So we said what's happening? They were going to California to form their group Return to Forever with Chick Corea. And so you know but that's a good point. I don't remember any — no, because Monk, we were creating. Because when you're really creating you don't know what's coming next. So I don't remember any of them, they came in later I think. But now, that's one thing that kind of upsets me about Sirius FM, you know, now it's the complete opposite.

MR: Say that again?

LLS: On the Sirius FM now it's the complete opposite as far as smooth jazz.

MR: Yes.

LLS: So you know we started it, what they call new age music, we were doing that back in the 70s. So you know.

MR: Yeah. I'm afraid that's happened a number of times before too, even with rock & roll.

LLS: Oh my goodness you're right. That's a good example. I mean in London they should have a statue, they should have knighted Jimi Hendrix, I mean Jimi Hendrix went to London that saved all those rock & roll groups that are making millions of dollars a day.

MR: Have you ever had critics or journalists say something about your music that you read, and going that wasn't the idea at all? Or something along those lines?

LLS: Oh yeah that' might happen. Because I remember back then I would play "A Garden of Peace" and some people would say you're putting me to sleep. Years later. Yeah, okay. But you know oh, a lot of times they said, when we were stretching out and I was using my fingers and my things to get more sound

[plays]

[plays]

so but they said well you know you were banging while you were — like you say I'll use your word, when things got strange — but it was nothing like that. Either you were banging or you were frustrated and you were getting all that frustration out — that had nothing to do with it, we were just pure sound and you were expanding and then — because I mean like when you go out, and that's why I love nature, you hear all these sounds, the birds and the water and the wind blowing through the trees and then, I mean all that's music. You know so I was just trying to be natural and naturistic.

MR: Yeah, well I read a quote from you in 2009 regarding your music, "I was trying to expand the consciousness of humanity."

LLS: Right.

MR: And I think you've done that, and we appreciate it.

LLS: All right thanks, Monk. That's what I was trying to do. That's what music's supposed to do man, because when I heard Charlie Parker that's what he did for me, and then we used to go catch, I remember the Five Spot in the Village, you could stand outside and we'd listen to Trane perform and you'd listen to Trane play one set I mean that music could inspire you and carry you for weeks and months. I mean that's what music's supposed to do for you.

MR: Awesome. Well on that note I'm going to pause our recording and then we'll say our good-byes, all right?

LLS: Okay, Monk.

MR: All right.